

The most important part about spending money with a partner is to recognize that you don't share identical values. Instead of judging your partner for wanting to spend on things you don't value, encourage them to prioritize what they love and seek to honor their top values as highly as your own. No matter how hard we want our partners to spend how we want them to spend, they usually see it as deprivation. When they see you want them to have what they love most, and more of it, the conversation shifts from "we have to save" to "we want to spend well." And speaking of conversation, we should reframe the questions we ask our partners with the same shifts we used on ourselves from chapter 2. Avoid "why" questions that put people on the defensive and genuinely seek to get curious about your partner's motivations for spending with questions like:

What do you value or enjoy spending money on most?

What's your philosophy on spending and how did you develop it?

What's your perspective on saving and how did you develop it?

What would you like to do with money in the future?

What would you like to see for our financial future?

You may also need to prepare yourself to find a trustworthy counselor to assist in getting on the same page. That in no way means a failure of your relationship. Oftentimes our heated financial conversations and ideologies around money are rooted in something far more intricate and important than what each other chooses to spend on. And we're not always the best at getting to the core on our own.

With kids, they not only cost a significant amount of money, but they also sucker you into buying stuff you weren't planning on buying. Mostly because they're so dang cute. Or you just want to avoid a public tantrum. Jen keeps a "tantrum avoidance" section in her spending plan for times such as these. Either way, the methods of prioritization still apply here. In the situations where adding extra things to the shopping cart or paying for activities every weekend is not an option, look for opportunities to provide for your kids' wants in inexpensive and creative ways. Like buying secondhand toys from Facebook Marketplace and taking advantage of your local library that offers free local museum passes, video game console rentals, and . . . books!